

Platform-Enabled People Governance (PEPG)

A Problem-Centered, Platform-Enabled Model for Distributed Public Governance

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Abstract

This paper proposes Platform-Enabled People Governance (PEPG), a conceptual model of public governance organized around problems rather than around a single institution, bureaucracy, or digital platform. PEPG places a public problem at the center and connects citizens, experts, government institutions, implementers, funders, contractors, and oversight actors through distributed participation spaces. The model distinguishes public participation in problem identification and solution development from controlled participation in implementation and formal oversight. It is intentionally platform-agnostic: WhatsApp, Telegram, X, GitHub, dedicated systems, or other communication and collaboration environments may serve as participation spaces without becoming the governance model itself. The paper further proposes that contracts, legislative inputs, reports, and other consequential records may be supported by tamper-evident or blockchain-based infrastructure where appropriate. PEPG aims to reduce excessive concentration of execution and oversight, expand societal capacity, accelerate large-scale decision and implementation processes, and preserve public traceability while retaining a coordinating and regulatory role for government.

Keywords: participatory governance; collaborative governance; digital governance; platform-enabled governance; distributed governance; public problem solving; civic participation; oversight; transparency

1. Introduction

Modern governments face a structural capacity problem: public problems are numerous, interconnected, geographically dispersed, and increasingly complex, while administrative institutions necessarily operate with finite personnel, budgets, information, and organizational bandwidth. Traditional bureaucratic arrangements are valuable for continuity, legality, and accountability, but they can also concentrate problem identification, implementation, and oversight within relatively narrow institutional chains. The result may be slow coordination, limited experimentation, and insufficient use of knowledge and capacity distributed throughout society.

Digital technologies create an opportunity to reorganize participation around public problems. Existing scholarship already examines governance platforms, digital participation, collaborative governance, and networked public administration. Research on governance platforms suggests that platforms can support distributed participation and mobilization, while studies of digital participation emphasize that no single platform design is suitable for all contexts. PEPG builds on these insights but proposes a specific organizing principle: **the public problem, rather than the institution or platform, should be the primary unit of coordination.**

2. Conceptual Foundation

PEPG is related to participatory governance, collaborative governance, network governance, and digital platform governance, but it is not identical to any one of them. Participatory governance emphasizes citizen involvement in public decision processes; collaborative governance emphasizes cooperation across public, private, and civic boundaries; and platform governance studies the institutional and technological arrangements through which multiple actors interact. PEPG combines these perspectives around a problem-centered architecture.

A key distinction is that PEPG does not require the state to abandon responsibility. Government remains an important actor: it can define legal boundaries, validate public claims, allocate or authorize budgets, approve access to

sensitive functions, enforce standards, and remain accountable for public outcomes. What changes is the assumption that government must itself perform every stage of problem solving.

3. The PEPG Model

A PEPG process can be represented as: **Problem Identification** → **Public Solutions** → **Funding** → **Implementation** → **Contracts** → **Oversight** → **Reporting**. These components are connected to a problem record, while the actual conversations and activities may occur in different external or internal spaces.

3.1 Problem Identification

Citizens and local actors can report problems through public participation spaces. A problem detector or registry can assign an identifier, preserve the description and provenance of the submission, and make the issue visible for further development. The proposer is identified, while subsequent contributions can be attributed to their respective participants.

3.2 Solution Development

Solution development is intentionally open. Citizens, professionals, universities, firms, civil-society groups, and other knowledgeable participants may propose alternatives. A PEPG registry does not need to host the discussion itself; it can link to an existing public group or community. This makes PEPG platform-agnostic and reduces dependence on a single technology provider.

3.3 Funding and Implementation

Funding information can be connected to the problem so that participants can understand the scale and source of resources. Implementation can then be organized through project-specific groups or entities. Unlike general public discussion, implementation may legitimately require controlled access because of procurement, safety, professional liability, security, or contractual requirements.

3.4 Independent Oversight

Oversight is deliberately separated from implementation. A monitoring group may be composed of authorized citizens, professional auditors, institutions, or other approved participants. The purpose is to reduce the risk that the same actors who execute a project also control its evaluation. Access rules should be explicit, reviewable, and subject to due process.

3.5 Contracts, Legislative Inputs, and Reports

PEPG can connect contracts, project records, legislative inputs, and reports to the problem record. Where appropriate, cryptographic signatures, immutable logs, distributed ledgers, or blockchain infrastructure can be used to strengthen provenance and tamper evidence. Such technology is not a defining requirement of PEPG; it is an optional trust and integrity layer. The same principle applies to legislative proposals: once formally submitted, versioned records can help demonstrate whether an input has been altered.

4. Platform-Agnostic Architecture

The term *platform-enabled* describes an architectural capability, not dependence on a particular application. A PEPG problem may link to a public WhatsApp group for local observations, a Telegram group for solution development, a GitHub repository for open documentation, a dedicated government system for formal records, and another service for public reporting. The governance model remains PEPG because the problem record connects these distributed spaces.

This distinction is important because digital platforms are themselves governed spaces with their own rules, ownership structures, algorithms, and incentives. PEPG therefore treats external platforms as interchangeable participation channels rather than as sovereign components of the governance model.

5. Preventing Concentration and Conflicts of Interest

A central design objective of PEPG is to reduce concentration in both execution and oversight. A project should not automatically become a closed chain in which one organization identifies the problem, selects the solution, executes the work, verifies completion, and controls the public narrative. Separating these functions creates opportunities for independent review and plural participation.

This separation does not mean that every participant must have equal authority in every function. PEPG instead proposes differentiated permissions: public access where openness improves collective knowledge; controlled access where professional, legal, procurement, or security considerations require it; and independent oversight where accountability requires separation.

6. Speed, Scale, and State Capacity

PEPG is intended to improve the speed of large-scale decision making by parallelizing problem solving. Instead of requiring a single administrative chain to sequentially perform diagnosis, ideation, procurement preparation, implementation coordination, and monitoring, different groups can work simultaneously around a shared problem record. Government can coordinate, validate, authorize, and intervene where necessary without monopolizing every operational task.

For major infrastructure or nationwide programs, this architecture could allow thousands of local observations, expert proposals, implementation capacities, and monitoring activities to be connected to a common program while preserving local initiative. The model therefore seeks not merely to make government digital, but to increase the effective problem-solving capacity of the wider governance system.

7. Protection Against External Influence

A distributed participation model also creates a need for safeguards against manipulation, coordinated foreign influence, fabricated identities, and strategic capture of decision-making. PEPG should therefore distinguish between open deliberation and formal authority. Public discussion can remain open, while access to implementation, sensitive information, procurement decisions, and formal oversight can require identity verification, eligibility rules, conflict-of-interest declarations, and institutional authorization.

The objective is not to exclude citizens, but to prevent an open communication environment from being confused with an unrestricted authority environment. Provenance, transparent participation rules, audit logs, independent review, and anomaly detection can help protect high-impact decisions without eliminating public contribution.

8. Example: Public Infrastructure Problem

Consider an abstract example: *poor asphalt quality on an abstract street in Tanzania*. The problem is registered as PEPG-0002. A public group collects photographs and local observations; another public group develops engineering and community solutions; funding information is connected to the issue; an authorized implementation group coordinates the work; contracts are published with version history; an approved oversight group independently monitors execution; and a public reporting channel publishes progress and results. The important point is that these groups do not have to exist on the same platform.

9. Governance and Institutional Requirements

PEPG should not be understood as an automatic substitute for law, public administration, procurement regulation, or democratic institutions. Its effectiveness would depend on clear rules concerning authority, data protection, accessibility, identity, procurement, liability, appeals, moderation, conflicts of interest, and accountability. Pilot programs should therefore test not only technological functionality but also institutional legitimacy and practical outcomes.

10. Limitations and Research Agenda

As a conceptual model, PEPG currently requires empirical validation. Important research questions include whether distributed participation actually accelerates implementation; how to prevent participation inequality; how government authorization should be designed; how external platforms affect continuity; how privacy can be preserved while maintaining public traceability; and which combinations of openness and access control produce the best outcomes.

Future work should include comparative pilots, measurable indicators of decision speed and project quality, experiments with different participation architectures, and evaluation of anti-capture mechanisms. Blockchain or other immutable-record technologies should be assessed on a case-by-case basis rather than assumed to improve governance automatically.

11. Conclusion

PEPG proposes a shift from institution-centered administration toward problem-centered coordination. Its central proposition is simple: when a public problem is clearly identified, the governance system should be able to connect the relevant knowledge, people, resources, implementation capacity, contracts, and independent oversight around that problem.

The model does not seek to eliminate government. It seeks to change the distribution of problem-solving capacity. Government retains public authority and accountability while society contributes knowledge, ideas, implementation capacity, monitoring, and feedback. By separating execution from oversight, using multiple participation channels, and maintaining a connected record of the problem, PEPG may reduce institutional bottlenecks, limit operational monopolies, increase transparency, and accelerate large-scale public action.

Ultimately, PEPG should be evaluated not by the sophistication of its technology, but by whether it enables a society to solve public problems faster, more transparently, more inclusively, and with stronger safeguards against concentration and capture.

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